

Eclipse- A story of loss, grief, and peace with death

What would the moon tell the sun if they spoke?

April 1,

Hydrophobia: (Noun)

An irrational fear of water.

Fear should be a deterrent, should it not? With every deep breath I take I am submerged under the water. My heart pulsates loud enough to deafen me. I've lived my entire life controlled by my fears, but now, death is on the horizon. In a bit, I'll be down with the worms in the dirt, paralyzed and hollow.

In the afterlife, when I meet the rest of the dead, what will I have to say for myself? A man brags about his time in the army... a woman talks about how she sailed around the world... and I stayed home. One might think it stupid to worry about the opinion another corpse may hold of you, but it's kept me up for about a week now. Something brushes my leg, I feel my heart skip a beat, I hate water.

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My body shivers as I take my seat on the blanket I'd laid down. The lake is calm. A second ago, it felt like the loudest place on earth, but now, the surface of the water is unmoving, and the grass is dancing to the rhythm of the wind. I take a folded piece of paper out of my pocket and place a green check mark next to '*the lake*'. This month will be a heavy one, that I have already fathomed.

I lay my body down on the blanket and close my eyes. My head is spinning, and my body feels shattered. I should be in a hospital. I shouldn't be at the lake...

Why do we always lie to ourselves? Tomorrow. Every person walks on this earth telling themselves Tomorrow. Tomorrow they'll accomplish everything they desire. Then, when they realize their tomorrows are limited, it's too late. I hate that it took me this long to realize I have nothing to show for my life.

I open my eyes again. The sun's heat has dried all the water off my skin. A small salamander starts making his way up my arm. I cup his small body in my hands as he stares up at me. *Ambystoma maculatum*. I recognize him from one of my late-night Wikipedia deep dives. He looks like he's still very little. "I envy you y'know" his wide eyes continue to stare at me as if listening to what I'm saying. "you've got 25 years ahead of you... that's longer than I'd ever gotten." I set him down near the edge of the blanket. He sits for a bit then walks off.

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After hours of waiting, the sun breaks below the horizon and lets out her array of lights. My hand reaches for the bracelet on my arm. Each bead is adorned with a white and red marble pattern. I pull at the string holding the beads lightly as Haroun's voice echoes in the back of my head. "I wonder what it would be like to be the sun." I miss having him around...

My mind spirals thinking of our time together. When I'm finally aware again, I notice the slight tang of blood on my tongue. In my daze, I was picking apart my skin with my teeth, and

now some blood has dripped down and out of my cuticles. It's fully dark now. I make sure my list is safely back in my pocket with my keys and fold the blanket I'd been laying on.

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April 6,

“Good morning Ms. Badr,

I’ve noticed you haven’t been attending my lectures recently. While I never really pay much attention to the ins and outs of my student's lives, it’s hard not to notice your absence. Going from the top of the class, front row seated, always participating to MIA is a peculiar shift if I’m honest. I hope this is only a temporary thing.

- Dr. Jane Kristoff”

My phone screen illuminated the room as I buried my face in my pillow. I haven’t been to Uni in 6 weeks. Watching my professor explain a condition I faced, having to sit there stone-faced, studying the ins and outs of AML, how low the survival rate is, how painful the treatments were... I was weak. I couldn’t handle it anymore. It’s one thing to push forward telling yourself “It’s all so I can help someone else get more time,” it’s another thing to know you won’t even live to see the payoff of your life’s work.

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Chemotherapy is a hell I wouldn’t wish on anyone... I feel like I’ve been robbed of everything that used to make me, me. At first, life cut my hair and told me to grow up. I traded in my 2 braids for shoulder-length hair. I presented myself to life, thinking I could now be an adult... but when I did, life was unhappy. It took away my hair and told me to stop growing. I still don’t know what I’d done to make it so angry.

I was a self-described hypochondriac for most of my life. The thing about disease is... it doesn't care if you're scared. It doesn't care if you're the most cautious person on earth. It takes. It takes and it takes, and it destroys everything you have. It doesn't care if you're 8 or 60, it'll rob anyone of everything they knew. My mom hates it when I say that I was robbed, but I think it's because deep down she knows I was.

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I get up off the bed after 3 hours... 3 hours wasted, yes, but my relationship with time has been confusing for the past few months. The room itself is a mess. Clothes are laid down in piles on the floor, I don't bother to keep things that clean now either. Shattered glass spilled out into the corner of my room from the cracked mirror. I broke the mirror 2 weeks ago. Even though I didn't purposefully pick it up and drop it, I don't know if I broke it by accident. I'd never carelessly break something, but a part of me was happy it shattered. Deep down I felt happy I would have a hard time seeing myself.

My keys are sprawled out on the drawer next to my bed, my lunar keychain hanging off the edge and slowly pulling the rest of the keys with it. I pocket the keys on my way out of the room.

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April 11,

The air is rich with the scent of burning wood. A small metal pale is lying on the floor near my sleeping bag. The watch on my wrist reads 21:00. I get up to fill the pale with water from the lake. It's dark out meaning the lake is pitch black. In my head, the lake looks like a pit through the earth. My legs freeze and I can't walk any closer to the lake. I don't have time for this.

After 30 minutes of slowly crawling towards the lake, I'm close enough to fill the pale up. I can feel my whole body screaming out in fear, but I still reach my hands out and fill the pale. I crawl backward then get up and run back to my fire. The water lands on it with a loud sizzle.

Achluophobia. That's the name of fear of darkness. As a kid, I was terrified of the darkness. The darkness has always just left too much for interpretation. As I grew up though, I started getting used to sleeping in the dark. I'd like to think that's more related to me having memorized the room after sleeping in it for 16 years and not that I'm suddenly braver than I was. So, with my hatred of the dark coupled with my already strong fear of open spaces, this camping trip is a nightmare.

Haroun always wanted us to go camping together. He thought it would be nice for it to just be me, him, and the moon for a bit. I finally caved in January and told him we could go in the summer when Uni work would be a lot less. I keep one of his books in my bag. Though I

hate being alone in the dark, the night sky is clearer than ever. I open the pages of the book, Ursa Major, I feel like he's here with me, pointing at the different stars and telling me their names.

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The night sky shifts from its deep black to a lighter navy. I lost track of the time watching the stars. Dawn will break soon. I take the folded list out of my pocket again and put a check next to 'camping'. From the corner of my eye, I spot the same spotted salamander from before. I play with the string on my bracelet again, "25 years alive huh... wouldn't that have been nice, Haru."

The moment my head hits the pillow I'd set down I'm asleep.

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April 13,

The lift moves up the line, leaving my sanity in shambles with every creak it makes. I hope the drive down here was worth it. My head has been spinning since this morning and the stress of being 90 ft above ground has not been helping. It's like every part of me woke up today on strike. Unluckily for my body though, I'm extremely stubborn.

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After an hour, the lift finally stopped near the top of the cliff. All that's left for me to do is hike up 30 more minutes. With every step forward I can feel the pit in my stomach growing. By the time I get near enough to the top, my insides will have turned into a bottomless void, maybe even devouring me fully before I look over the edge of the cliff.

The sun's heat continued burning my skin as I dragged my feet across the rocks. Slowly, with every step, it feels as if my legs are becoming one with the cliff. My breaths grow shorter as time passes. What was it I said about a bottomless void? It's like the earth's crust has opened and I'm being swallowed by the ground. The corners of my peripheral get darker by the minute, occasionally my vision flashes a white screen. The inevitable happens, and my body collapses to the ground. Even when I try to push forwards, my body will never let me forget that deep down, my insides have rotted, and my body is not on my side.

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I'm propped up against a large rock on the cliff. My legs and arms are scattered with red scratches and spots. One side of my face feels raw and bloody to the touch. A young girl stares back at me with a worried expression on her face. "Are you okay?" she says, but her voice feels distant. I bring my knees up to my chest and curl myself up for a bit. I want this to be over. The girl says something I can't decipher in the background. Whatever it is, I let out a slight groan in response. It's like the world is continuously crashing down on me. The girl speaks to someone and soon enough I feel myself being lifted off the ground.

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April 14,

I've been on my back staring at the ceiling since my eyes opened 2 hours ago. I failed. Somewhere in my head, a comforting voice tells me it's not my fault. I didn't choose to be sick. But I can't help but feel at fault for most of what's happening. I chose to waste my life planning for the next day. Why was I so stupid? Now everything's out of my hands.

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A few more hours pass, staying still on the bed. I wipe the tears off my face and grab the piece of paper on my drawer. I track my eyes down to the words 'the cliff' and mark down an x alongside them.

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April 17,

For the past 3 days, I've been sitting in my room wallowing in sadness. Every day that passes I can feel my physical state getting worse. It's as if I've already died and now, I'm just waiting to be buried.

I'm starting to give up on the list, and everything really. It's hard to keep motivated when it feels like you're losing everything you have. At this rate saying that I'm losing everything is just a poor excuse for a joke. I've lost everything. It's all gone. Every step that I'm taking forwards is just killing me faster. Life isn't going to give me a second chance no matter what I do, so why do I keep trying?

For the first time in a while, I reach for the keys laying on the floor next to my bed.

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"Haru.

Do you remember the first time you showed me the lake? You were always nervous showing me new places, I always found it adorable. You would try to hide it too, but I could tell you were slightly worried. You would ask me a million times after if I liked the place, if I was having fun, and so on; I would always give you the same answer, "I'd go anywhere with you".

That day you had called me at 4:00. I was trying my best to sound awake and happy on that call, but you could tell I'd been stressed over Uni for hours. You could always tell if I'm

honest. The call went silent for a bit. Then, quietly, you asked if I wanted to watch the sunrise with you.

That day, you took me to the lake and asked me to forget about Uni for a few hours, and I happily did. In your arms, the entire world fell silent. I was at peace. Had I known our time together wouldn't be as long as I wanted it to be, I would have called you down to that lake every day. I would've done a lot of things differently if I'd known.

By the time the sun began rising, you were slowly starting to fall asleep. I don't think you would remember, but in your tired state, you asked me if I saw myself ever falling in love with you. I was too scared to say it back then, so I buried my head in your chest to hide my blush.

I still keep the bracelet I stole from you that night on my wrist. I can't take it off. And the keychain you gave me. 'a little moon for my little moon' you called it. It was so stupid, I loved it.

Everything reminds me of you. The flowers in the streets, the music I listen to, even the clothes I wear. Everything I come across has your name spelled across it, almost as if my heart is begging me not to forget you. Or maybe it's you. Maybe I've lost it completely, but it sometimes feels as if you left part of your spirit with me so I wouldn't be alone. It's almost supernatural the way I feel your presence in the world around me. Haru... you showed me love in a way no one had.

You wondered what it would be like to be the sun. As cliché as it sounds, you are my sun, Haru. You brought so much light into my life, love. With your loss, I lost a part of me. Now I'm desperately chasing after reigniting the light I lost. I hope that you look down on me with pride while in heaven, I feel like I've been quite hard to watch since I lost you.

What would the moon tell the sun if they spoke?

"I miss you."

What would the moon tell the sun if they spoke?

"I love you."

I lost my moonlight without my sun.

I'll see you soon,

Maya"

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The desk drawer barely opens. I pull an empty envelope out of the pile on my desk and fold the letter. I leave the envelope in the desk drawer with the rest of them.

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April 23,

The machines around me let out a slight electronic beep every once in a while. At first, the beeps greatly annoyed me; it's been so long now though that I've forgotten what it would be like without them. For the past 6 days, I've been trapped in a hospital bed. My physical state has gotten a lot worse since the start of the month. Every slight movement in my body sends streams of pain through my veins.

I haven't spoken much to anyone, not even the medical staff. Most of the time my neck is swollen and painful, even if I did want to talk, I wouldn't be able to.

Even still, I don't like being left to my thoughts and I think the nurse can tell. I assume that's why she comes and speaks to me so often. I appreciate the company sometimes.

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April 26,

The past few days have been some of the loneliest I've ever had. I'd started hating the moments the machines around me don't beep. It's as if the few seconds of silence in between the beeps serve to remind me of the years of silence awaiting me. I didn't want to die young. I didn't want to die sick and alone. None of this was supposed to happen... I didn't even finish the list, I can't do anything.

I'm not ready to die, please don't let me die.

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April 29,

0:00

As a kid, I hated getting help from people. For some reason, a voice in my head has always made me think I don't deserve to receive help, but I am required to provide it for others. I feel like I've dedicated my whole life to serving other people constantly, both in and out of my career. I love medicine. I love my field of study and I've taken a genuine interest in it through the years. I can't help but think that maybe if I let myself think I can be slightly selfish sometimes, I would have gone down a very different path in my life.

I don't even know my own hobbies. I know I love reading but the last time I read a non-academic novel was ages back... I've only focused on preparing for Uni my whole life. Even old "diary entries" of mine could practically be categorized as study logs with occasional input on my day.

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1:00

I used to like art as a kid, I think. I remember when I first went away to Uni my mom had told me about a box of my old drawings she'd found. The latest one had a little signature at the bottom,

“MAyaR BadR 2 Grde”

My mom said she found my little scribbly handwriting and (to this day) terrible spelling cute. She offered to mail me the drawings, but I told her I had nowhere to keep them. My desk is flooded with books most of the time. I didn't mean to lose myself in my career, I just wanted to make my family and myself proud.

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2:00

My dad was the first person to introduce me to medicine. He was a practicing doctor in the town hospital. We came from a small town, so everybody knew each other. While I may have missed out on some privileges city kids got, I got to go into the hospital since I was a kid. I was my father's "little assistant doctor" whenever I had time off school.

Patients often liked having little distractions in the hospital room, so they didn't mind having a little kid run around trying to put a smile on their faces. To a sick person, anything is better than being alone all the time.

I remember how much I loved helping others, it's why I chose to be a doctor.

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3:00

I can't help but think most of my fears stem from the fact that I'm terrified of not being in control. I hate the water because I can't control myself or my surroundings. I hate the dark because I can't see what's happening around me... I never used to be afraid of death until I got sick.

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4:00

Why am I not happy with myself? Why am I so ashamed? I've been spending all this time trying to figure out what I can do to make myself feel proud of myself before I die... why?

I've always been a huge perfectionist, maybe that was my downfall. The times that I've been happy have been the times I didn't spend obsessing over every little part of my life.

I've been obsessing over perfecting something impossible to perfect and in the process, I lost myself.

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5:00

I want to find comfort in death. After months of pain, I want to find comfort in anything.

Maybe it won't be that bad. I'll get to see you again, right?

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The sun breaks through the blinds ever so slightly. I've been up all night again. I turn my head to try and watch the sunrise through gaps in the blinds. It's beautiful as it always is.

The corners of my eyes sting me. My whole body has been begging me for rest. I keep them closed for a few minutes, still, my brain refuses to let me sleep. The staff will be in soon to start their morning rounds.

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"i miss you"

"i love you"

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April 30,

In the distant background, panicked voices surround me. Behind the crowd of frightened voices, a drawn-out screech of a machine plays. The noise occasionally stops only to start up again a few seconds later. Eventually, the noise stays on. For the first time in weeks, there's no pain in my body. Maybe one of the new medications they gave me helped numb the pain.

The people's voices die down all of a sudden. Everyone stays silent until a man begins speaking. I use anything left in me to make out what he's saying.

"I'm sorry," who is he apologizing to, they should all be happy, shouldn't they? The medications are working. I'm not in pain anymore. "we did everything we could."

I try to listen in on the rest of what he says but his voice fades out again. I don't understand what's going on. "Why is everything so quiet... I don't get it. For the first time, I've felt okay and everyone's sad..."

After a moment of silence, I can open my eyes again. I'm somehow back at the lake. I hear a familiar voice sitting beside me, "Mayz, baby, I missed you so much." After the longest time, I found my comfort in death.